

Human Bites

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Because human teeth are not particularly sharp, most human bites cause no injury or just a bruise and a shallow wound ([laceration](#)). Exceptions are on fleshy appendages, such as the ears or nose, which may be severed.

The clenched-fist injury, or "fight bite," which occurs on the knuckles of a person who punches another person in the mouth, is likely to become [infected](#). A clenched-fist bite injury frequently involves the finger tendon that passes over the knuckle.

Sometimes the biting person transmits infections, such as [hepatitis](#). Transmission of the [human immunodeficiency virus](#) (HIV) due to a human bite is extremely unlikely because the concentration of the virus in saliva is lower than that in blood and because substances in saliva inhibit the virus's activity.

(See also [Introduction to Bites and Stings](#).)

Symptoms of Human Bites

Human bites are painful and usually produce a mark on the skin with the pattern of the teeth. Fight bites typically leave only a small, straight cut over a knuckle. A lacerated finger tendon often results in difficulty moving the finger in one direction. Infected bites become very painful, red, and swollen.

Did You Know...

- Transmission of HIV infection as a result of a human bite wound is highly unlikely.

Treatment of Human Bites

- Wound cleaning
- Antibiotics

Human bites are cleaned by flooding the wound with sterile salt water (saline) and cleaning it with soap and water.

Tears, except those involving the hand and those that have occurred many hours ago, are usually surgically closed.

Most people with human bites that have broken the skin are given antibiotics by mouth to prevent infection. Infected bites are treated with antibiotics. If a fight bite becomes infected, hospitalization may be needed if treatment with intravenous antibiotics is needed. Infected bites sometimes must be opened surgically to root out foreign objects (for example, a broken tooth) and clean the wound. Sometimes an imaging study such as an x-ray or ultrasound is also done to locate hidden foreign objects.

If the biting person is known or suspected to have a disease that may be spread by biting, preventive treatment may be necessary.

